

able to connect your PC to a UPS as it also prevents problems caused by power failures, rather than using just a stabilizer or CVT. APC and Emerson are a couple of good brands you can consider.

Power puff!

Q. I've recently purchased a Compaq Presario that has a P4 1.6 GHz, 128 MB RAM, and a 40 GB hard drive. After a few months, it stopped working properly. It turns off suddenly, a few minutes after I start my PC. When I reboot my PC, it takes a lot of time and shows a red light. Please suggest a solution.

Vickey Kumar

A. There could be a number of reasons for this. First of all, this can occur when the inside of the cabinet gets heated. Check if the power supply fan, at the back of the tower, is working properly when the PC turns off abruptly. If it isn't, then it is a power supply issue. Call the service engineer if your machine is under warranty.

If your machine is not under warranty, then follow the instructions given below, but only if you have previous hardware experience. Ground yourself properly by touching a metal or wear an anti-static strap. Power off the PC, and open the cabinet. Check whether the RAM and video card are properly seated. Ensure that the monitor cable on the back of the video card is properly tightened. Now turn on the PC, and see whether the processor fan and the fan on the video card are spinning properly. Leave it like this, and see if the computer remains on. If it goes off, then there is an issue with one of these three components. Remember that you can only narrow down the possibilities of a fault in components such as these. If there is a problem with the motherboard, then you will not be able to detect it easily.

RAM happy

Q. I have a Compaq Presario 5000, built around the i810 motherboard. How can I dedicate more RAM to my integrated graphics chip?

Nitin Kundra

A. The Intel i810 uses a technology called Dynamic Video Memory Technology (DVMT). The OS will typically require allocation of up to 1 MB of system memory to support legacy VGA. This means that system utilities will report 1 MB less

than the actual physical memory onboard. The graphics driver for the i810 configuration can request up to 6 MB of memory from the OS to maintain the i810's maximum screen resolution of 1,024 x 768, 2 MB for a command buffer and 4 MB for Z-buffering. For high performance 3D applications, the drivers request larger allocations of system memory for AGP graphics textures. When the 3D application is closed, the OS will then re-allocate system memory back for normal Windows use. So the integrated graphics chipset will pick up the video RAM allocation from the system memory. Increasing the system memory should provide you with more video RAM. You can also refer to the users' manual that came along with the computer to see if you have BIOS settings to allocate more RAM for your video applications. This is typically found in the Advanced Chipset Settings or Integrated Peripherals sections of the BIOS.

Getting rid of Linux

Q. I have a peculiar problem with my Zenith PC, which has a Pentium 4, 128 MB and a 40 GB hard drive that has five partitions. I had Windows and Linux installed on different partitions. To format and re-install Windows from a scratch, I used FDISK, and deleted the non-DOS partition and then the logical, extended and primary partitions, one after the other. I recreated the partitions (without the non-DOS partition), and formatted the disk. The problem now is that, if I boot from the hard drive, GRUB

of Linux appears in the command line. Also, the Windows setup doesn't proceed, giving a cryptic message and starts the thorough scandisk on the system. Is there a way out?

Anirban Sen

A. GRUB stores the details of your boot partitions on your Master Boot Record (MBR). But since you deleted the partitions and created new ones, it has no relevance now. Also, when you installed Windows, it did not clear the MBR. So the information is still present in a corrupted manner. Flushing the MBR, and installing Windows again can solve this problem. The command to flush the MBR using FDISK is `fdisk /mbr`. Do this using a boot floppy. This will clear your MBR and after that, you can move on to the Windows installation.

Bad cookies

Q. How dangerous can cookies be, and how does a hacker get information about my computer using cookies?

Amit Dugar

A. In general, cookies are stored as text files and can cause no harm to your PC or spread viruses. Hackers—or rather, commercially driven Web sites with no regard for your privacy—surreptitiously plant cookies and then retrieve them in such a way that it allows them to build a detailed profile of your interests, spending habits and lifestyle, making you a prime target for e-mail based advertising.

Trojan at your backdoor

Q. The Backdoor Sdbot Virus has infected my Windows system file, i.e., `msvcrt.exe`. I have used Norton AntiVirus 2002 to amend this, but to no avail—it has only quarantined the file, not repaired it. Please give me a solution.

Gurpreet

A. This virus is a Trojan horse that allows the hacker to control your computer. It can also update itself regularly using the Internet. The virus shows up under the file name `cnfgldr.exe` or `sysmon16.exe` in the task manager. The executable files can be found in the `c:\windows\system` folder. The only way to repair the

infected files is to download the removal tool from www.symantec.com, or from www.pandasoftware.com. Execute this program, which will analyse all the files and remove all strains of the virus from the machine.

